

Tough skin protects dugong

Soft seabed

SWIMMING OVER a soft seabed, using a mask and snorkel, it is possible to see only a few animals because most of them live buried in the sand. Look closely and you may see signs of buried life (a crab's feathery antennae or a clam's siphon), which help these animals get a clean supply of water containing oxygen to breathe. Some fish, like the eagle ray, visit the soft seabed to feed on burrowing clams. Other animals are found only where sea grasses grow on sandy bottoms. Sea grasses are not seaweeds but flowering plants. They are food for many animals, including dugongs and manatees—the only plant-eating marine mammals.

DOCILE DUGONG
Dugongs live in shallow tropical waters where they feed on sea grasses growing in the soft seabed. They

often dig down into the sand to eat the food-rich roots of sea grasses. These gentle, shy animals are still hunted in some places.

Anemonelike polyp unfurls when feeding

ELEGANT PEN
Looking like an old-fashioned quill pen, this relative of sea anemones lives in the soft seabed. The rows of tiny polyps which come out on each side of its body are used to capture small animals drifting by for food. Sea pens glow in the dark if disturbed. Some sea pens grow on the bottom of the deep ocean.

This sea pen can grow to 8 in (20 cm) in height

Long dorsal fin runs along almost whole length of body

Long anal fin

Red band fish may grow to 28 in (70 cm) in length

Stem of sea pen anchors in sandy seabed

SHELL BOAT
In Botticelli's *The Birth of Venus*, the Roman goddess rises from the water in a scallop shell. In real life, scallop shells are too heavy to float and much too small to carry a person.

RED BAND FISH
This fish usually lives in burrows in the soft seabed, down to depths of about 650 ft (200 m). It is also found swimming among sea grasses. Sometimes red band fish are found washed up on the beach after storms. When out of its burrow, the fish swims by passing waves down its body. It feeds on small animals drifting by.